



India's campaign was dominant from start to finish. The team beat Sri Lanka, Australia, Nepal, the USA and Pakistan in the league stage before outclassing Australia in the semifinal. In the final at the P. Sara Oval in Colombo, India cruised to a seven-wicket win over Nepal to seal a historic title.

For many of these players, who grew up in households where even two square meals a day were uncertain, the title and the attention that followed became a validation of years of quiet perseverance.

"After the win, villagers and relatives are constantly visiting to congratulate my parents. The sarpanch also met them and said that I have made the whole village proud. This is a very emotional moment for me. Our hard work is finally paying off," said Sunita Sarathe, who finished the tournament with eight wickets, speaking to *The Print*.

Much of the team's journey has

been shaped by the work of the Samarthanam Trust for the Disabled and its founder G.K. Mahantesh, who has championed blind cricket for decades. Through year-round tournaments and structured training programmes, Samarthanam has provided the framework that mainstream cricketing bodies have long denied.

"We had no practice facilities in our village. Some of us did not even have rice to eat. It is only the Cricket Association for the Blind in India (CABI) and Samarthanam Trust which has supported us," Deepika told Prasar Bharati Sports.

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah announced a cash reward of Rs. 10 lakh each and government jobs for players from Karnataka, along with Rs. 2 lakh each for players from other States.

Yet the larger battle remains unresolved. CABI chairman Mahantesh has renewed his call for official recognition from the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI).

India remains among the few cricketing nations where blind cricket operates without direct board backing, a major roadblock to the sport's growth.

As it stands, CABI and Samarthanam struggle to meet travel and operational costs, while players continue to earn little from the sport. The quest for BCCI recognition, Mahantesh said, remains in limbo.

"Support from the BCCI will make a huge difference. Additionally, it will be helpful if the International Cricket Council (ICC) advises all its member nations to support blind cricket globally. Yes, India is dominating now, but we want more countries to start playing," Mahantesh said.

"Governments from all States should provide facilities for all players, on par with what is provided for other sports. Lastly, if corporates can come on board and extend a helping hand in terms of sponsorship, blind cricket will grow and the players will benefit a great deal," Mahantesh said.



From Colombo's triumph to the corridors of power: Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets India's visually impaired world champions after their historic Blind T20 World Cup win. ANI



How blind cricket is played

The ball is larger than a regular cricket ball and contains ball bearings, producing a rattling sound to help batters locate it. Teams are made up of three classifications:

B1: Fully visually impaired

B2: Partially visually impaired

B3: Partially sighted

Each team must field a balanced combination of all three categories.

Fielders rely heavily on verbal communication and sound cues. The game follows most core cricket laws with modifications to ensure safety and accessibility. A match in full flow stands as a powerful testament to human resilience and adaptability.